

## ON TECHNIQUE

### Complex innovations

Charles Ives built his radical compositions on a deep knowledge of European classical music. He explored and extended the possibilities for creative adventure in techniques used sparingly in the past for their shock value or novel effect. These included polytonality and polyrhythm, respectively the simultaneous use of two or more keys and the simultaneous use of different rhythms; the inclusion of many different musical styles within the same piece, from ragtime songs and camp-meeting hymns to complex counterpoint and echoes of Bach and Brahms; harmonic ambiguity; layering of multiple themes, textures, and timbres; and collages evoking city sounds and public occasions.

Charles Ives earned a living by selling insurance but he composed music in his spare time. His liberal politics were inspired by an optimistic faith in “the people,” which was reflected in the popular songs that are woven into so many of his compositions.

“ The word ‘**beauty**’ is as **easy** to use as the word ‘**degenerate.**’ **Both** come in **handy** when one does or does not **agree** with you. ”

CHARLES IVES, 1920